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Accessibility, Usability, and Universal Design Beyond “Us” and “Them”

Per-Olof Hedvall, Professor of Design, Mid Sweden University

“Difference is the condition of everyone”

- What does this mean?
  - We’re all different. Every single I. Every single you.
  - We’re all part of human variation.
- Universal Design starts from that and builds for it
- Two challenges to make this real
  1. The with-without, norm-deviation, us-them thinking
  2. Well done UD is often tacit



Ad fontes! To the sources!

“What is universal design? Universal design is simply a way of designing a building or facility, at little or no extra cost, so it is both attractive and functional for all people, disabled or not.”



By Ronald L. Mace, AIA

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Barrier Free Environments For Everyone

The home or apartment building of the future will not have special concessions for disabled and elderly people. Instead, it will be usable by all people as a result of "universal design." So predicts Raleigh, North Carolina, architect Ronald L. Mace, AIA, one of the country's foremost authorities on accessible design and the father of the concept of universal design.

Mace is president of Barrier Free Environments, Inc., a design firm that specializes in design for disabled and elderly people. He is also chairman of the board of Information and Development Corporation (IDC), an information service company developing and marketing data on accessible design and products.

What is universal design? Universal design is simply a way of designing a building or facility, at little or no extra cost, so it is both attractive and functional for all people, disabled or not. The idea is to remove that expensive, "special" label from products and designs for people with mobility problems and, at the same time, eliminate the institutional appearance of many current accessible designs.

The concept of universal design will find growing support in the decade ahead as the graying of America produces an ever-larger pool of people with physical limitations. Universal design is the only economically feasible answer to this growing need for access.

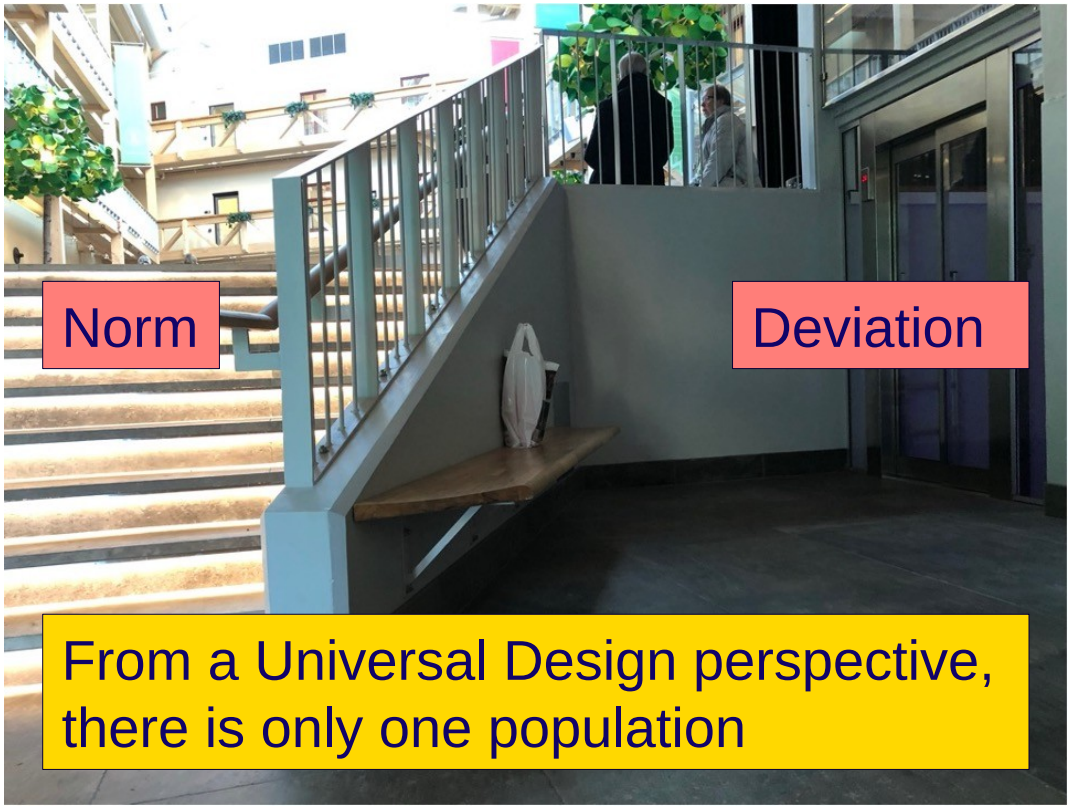
The first challenge: a culture based on “us” and “them” vs. a culture based on difference

An example of ”us” and ”them” from a policy text:

- “People with disabilities can move around and use all indoor and outdoor environments in the city on equal terms with others.”
- The division can be avoided with a slight adjustment to the text: “All residents can move around and use all indoor and outdoor environments in the city.”

(Analysis by Prof. Stina Ericsson, The Syntax of Equality project)

”Us” and ”them” in the built environment



Designing for difference, beyond “us” and “them”

- Three ways to move beyond “us” and “them”
  - Design for situations
  - Categorise the environment, not the body or the person.
  - Meet variation with variation

(For more examples, see nonclusive.org)

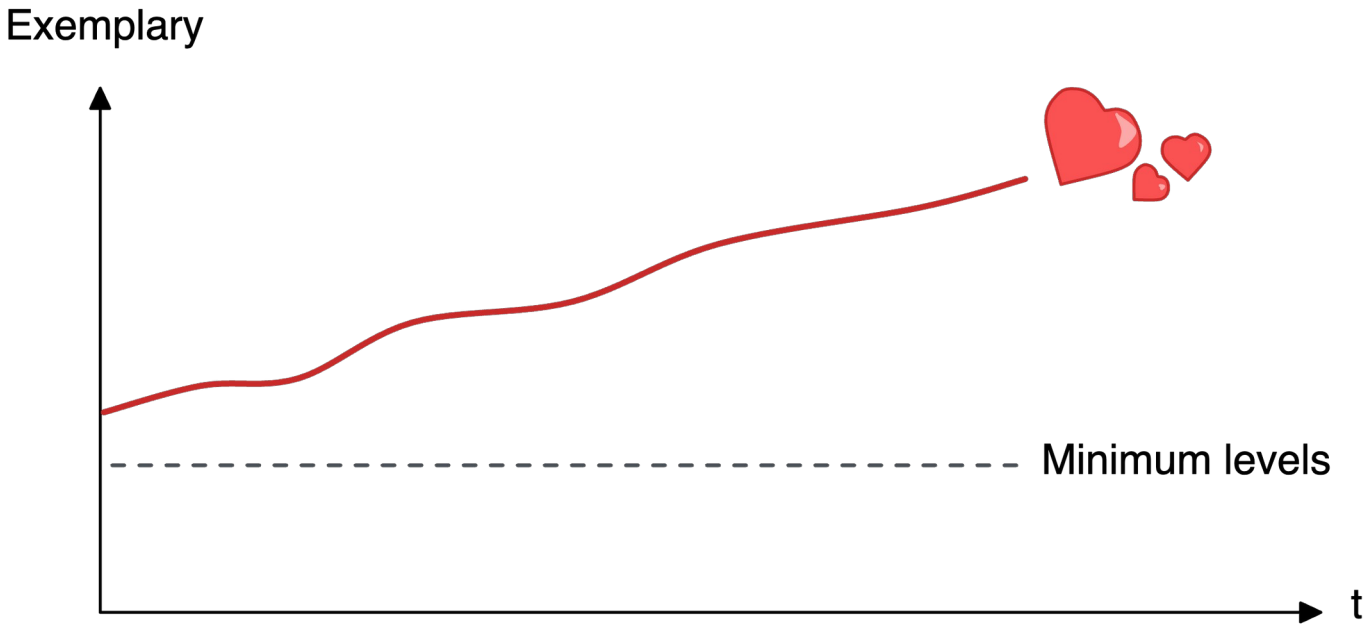


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Shaping a future of Universal Design, a future of everyone, a future of difference

- For many of the students that arrive at universities today, it is nothing new that people are different.
  - Provide chances to explore the connection between design and diversity.
  - Working with their own perspective, including seeing us and them, and the tacit qualities of Universal Design.
- The shift from norm and deviation to variation for an organisation is not gradual – it is a flip
- For design this shift entails new questions. When you ask, “Can everyone use this?” (variation) you’re asking a different question than “Do we provide access?” (“we” who provide “them”)

The second challenge: Universal Design is often tacit



Universal Design is about societal change

“Universal design is ultimately about changing attitudes throughout society, emphasizing democracy, equity, and citizenship. Universal design denotes a process more than a definite result.”

(Iwarsson and Ståhl, 2003, p.62)

Unburdening Universal Design from compliance

- What if UD and its contributions were followed on its own terms?
  - Its output (what gets built or made because of UD),
  - its process (how it is planned, designed and decided, and who takes part), and
  - its societal impact (what it does to society over time).
- Good proxy indicators for UD's societal impact?
  - Trust in other people?
  - Respect for other people's rights?
  - Democratic participation?



What would you follow over time regarding UD’s societal impact?

Today, at 11.00, we will present our paper:

“Benchmarking Accessibility, Usability, and Universal Design – What Kind of Society Are We Building?”

Come and contribute to our workshop tomorrow afternoon, at 14:30:
“What Makes Universal Design Visible? A Workshop on Direct and Proxy Indicators”
(Both by Hedvall, Müller, McNutt, and Craddock)

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“What kind of society are we building?”

Let’s keep this discussion going! 😊